By virtually all accounts, the government failed miserably in responding to cyclone Nargis. The PONJA report painted a distorted picture of the efforts of the regime. The government claimed that after the cyclone struck, both the SPDC and Myanmar's army assisted in relief efforts. The regime claimed to help with relief supplies, medical care, infrastructural repair, and reestablishing security. Eyewitness testimonies state that the reality was much different. It was obvious that the tatmadaw was the only organization in Myanmar with the manpower, resources, and communication ability to deal with such a catastrophe. Not only did the junta fail to respond in a timely manner, but they also stalled any sort of international assistance from initially reaching the most vulnerable areas devastated. The local authorities were unsuccessful in coordinating action. Corruption also plagued the initial efforts as authorities kept relief supplies, selling them on the black market. This illegal action included diversion of donated goods for resale and forced labor being performed by villagers. Camp conditions were appalling with little or no aid going to victims. The SPDC seemed to focus more on maintaining law and order rather than assisting those in need.

Foreign workers were continually denied access to the victims. Many of the aid organizations were stuck in the urban areas, such as Yangon, for long periods of time. The regime hampered efforts and set up obstacles throughout the early stages of the process. The international community expressed continued frustration at the regime's lack of effort and concern and urged the regime to accept international assistance. A full two weeks after the cyclone hit, aid was still not making it to the Ayeyarwaddy region.

The United Nations was informed on May 23 that aid workers would be allowed into the areas hit by Nargis. The announcement was met with skepticism from observers who felt the regime was trying to deflect criticism and secure more money. The SPDC continued to restrict access to most areas. The UN Human Rights Council passed a resolution calling on the government to allow immediate, full, and unhindered access. Approximately 200 UN staff members were allowed to visit affected areas, but the numbers were so small as to make the impact minimal. By mid June, only about half of the affected people had received any assistance.

Internal assistance from activists, celebrities, monks, and ordinary citizens was organized early on. Unfortunately, the SPDC also blocked these internal efforts to mitigate the suffering. Restrictions were put in place